

Life's like that

A funny thought struck me recently while doing a little research for our cover story this month. I hope you don't mind me sharing it, despite its rather random nature.

I was looking back at various technologies, specifically with regard to VR and AR, etc, and it got me thinking about a lot of the other tech that we've experienced in the past decade or two. They have a generic sort of history to them. Exceptions exist, surely, but broadly this template might fit most technologies.

Technologies all usually have some things in common. They all start off as a dream that almost consumes a person or persons. The creators reach a point in their life where the idea of birthing the technology is almost all consuming. Agreed, sometimes the idea and conception of the technology is almost unplanned and spontaneous... but more commonly it takes a fair amount of planning and scheduling.

Once the idea is formed there's a lot of reading up to be done, a little experimentation here and there and then finally the spirit of the technology is conceived. It's nothing spectacular, and looks nothing like a finished technology yet, but it's something.

It's certainly enough of something to make its creators proud. It's all they can talk about. With wildly varying gestation periods, and some mad moments later, a technology is finally born. Pre-alpha versions are what some people call them, and they're usually pretty useless things; they're ugly, create a mess, and aren't even shaped right, but dare you tell their creators that...they can already see their technology taking over the world!

As version numbers pass, the technology starts to take a better form, and actually starts looking somewhat like a finished product. Features get added on and the creators find it hard to keep pace. Changelogs struggle to keep up, version numbers keep incrementing, and new features are almost expected. It's still nothing close to a mature technology, but it's finished enough to hand out to beta testers for part time use and study.

At some stage in the developmental process the technology seems poised to become The Greatest Ever™, at least in the eyes of the creators, and then bugs start showing. As the technology is exposed to more systems, the bugs can sometimes take a turn for the ugly, and cause the creators endless nights of worry and fear. At one point it almost seems like their very existence is to find and fix

bugs, and any further development is almost forgotten about.

After a number of version numbers pass, the creators realise that it's time to unleash the technology on the world, and make a release candidate – some go as far as open sourcing it. This is the stage where advertising is needed, and the creators have to shell out money to get the world to accept their creation.

Usually acceptance follows, and depending on how good the technology is, either a small or very large group adopts it and accepts it into their lives. This is the mature stage for the technology and is also the stage where it seems to add on features and gathers the most amount of data, very quickly.

Often the technology finds a niche for itself that even the creators never imagined possible. Though, sometimes the creators are very overbearing and don't allow any experimentation with the technology, insisting that it stay on the planned path, and this can work well too, for some technologies.

Sometimes two technologies are converged and start a new line of thought that can yield even newer technologies with some traits of both the parent technologies. This happens more often than you'd imagine, as almost all technology today carries some traits that can be traced back to a myriad older techs.

Eventually, however, all technologies age, and newer ones challenge them for their positions. The newer technologies are often better developed and more efficiently coded to either accomplish the same tasks faster, or accomplish more diverse tasks. Either way the days of the older technology are numbered. Some make a comeback for a short time, but usually they're finally retired or left catering to a niche set that requires nothing more.

Slowly but surely, the usefulness dwindles, and then the technology finally dies, with some references left scattered about it on the web. Now and then it's name may surface in the memories of a few, but eventually it's forgotten. Completely. In just a few generations or less.

Oh well, such is life... for technologies, and also... well, us. It's almost like technologies are alive, living and dying just as we do. 



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
robert@digit.in

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